

Re: Reading assignment: "All-In"

Name/Email: Shaira Katuwal, skatuwal@iu.edu

Date: 25th January, 2026

As I read All-In alongside my early experiences with my current team, the article feels less like an abstract on leadership philosophy and more like a framework I can test in real time. The purpose of me reading the article is to try and answer what being "all-in" means for my group. For this project, we are a team of four people with distinct work styles: two teammates who are more calm, quiet, and highly analytical, one teammate who thrives on interaction and small talk and brings energy to group discussions, and myself, someone who enjoys collaboration and idea exchange but also values working in solitude, deep thinking, and questioning my ideas privately before presenting them to a group or stepping back to analyze a conversation. When thinking from a diversification angle, this is a great mix but in practice, it also raises an important question: what does it actually mean for a group like ours to be fully "all-in"?

NASA's track record on Mars is a powerful illustration of the article's core claim that when people are fully committed to a shared mission within the right environment, outcomes that appear impossible become achievable. At the same time, this example serves as a reminder that such cultures take time to build and deliberate. While a classroom project cannot replicate NASA's scale, the principle still applies towards shaping a team culture.

My immediate takeaway was that to reach the "all-in" stage, how we define "all-in" becomes extremely important, as that definition shapes culture itself. If each individual contributes differently and signals commitment in different ways, then a single definition risks being both unrealistic and unfair. Reading this article makes me contemplate our team's early progress with regard to its relation with what has been proposed by the author in his discussion of commitment, environment, and leadership.

Our first task was to reach out to two to three professional contacts each via LinkedIn to propose a potential project sponsor. Ideally, the project would deliver something genuinely useful to the sponsor while giving us exposure to real-world valuation work. Almost immediately, this task has revealed how differently commitment is displayed across individuals. Some of my team members took a different approach by being quiet and deliberate, offering information upon request. Their version of being all-in was being deliberate, being preparatory, and being responsive rather than being extremely present. Another team member went all-in on being present, communicating frequently, personalizing email templates, having updates, such as being engaged and moving forward, to signify being all-in commitment.

Being all-in, for me, means creating a strategy, determining whom to reach out to, determining the kind of projects I expected to propose, and determining the implication of such efforts beyond a course-related task. Hence, at this stage, I had the fewest number of contacts I had reached out to, but I had been more deliberate. This forced me to confront some uncomfortable but necessary questions: is one teammate's approach better than others? If so should we all be following a set approach or diversify as we have till yet and see where this lands us. Does being all-in mean doing more visibly?

The article suggests that extraordinary outcomes arise not when people behave uniformly, but when the environment allows different strengths to come to light without being misinterpreted. This perfectly resonated with me as I believe alignment on intent matters far more than alignment on expression. So does this mean conflict in teams is driven by unequal effort, or by unequal interpretations of effort? In academic teams especially, visibility is often substituted for value. Speaking more, sending more messages, or appearing constantly active can be mistaken for higher commitment, while quieter, analytical contributions risk being undervalued and unseen. Again this reinforces that judging contribution purely on qualitative signals or purely on quantitative outputs would both be incomplete, unfair, and potentially damaging. Furthermore, when effort is misread, the team is more likely to lose trust and erode even when motivation is very genuine.

Followed by one of the article's strongest arguments, that people disengage not because they lack motivation, but because the environment does not invite their strengths. Prioritizing psychological safety, mutual respect, and trust feels especially relevant in a team-based class where incentives are imperfect and built around stricter timelines. Reflecting on myself, I realized that ownership is what pulls me fully in. When I am not rushed, I am trusted to think through project structure, which is when I feel invested. But that investment only deepens when those ideas are engaged with, challenged, and refined collectively by my team members.

One more thing to consider while we look at scale and approach, is the setting in which a team is formed. In a classroom setting, deliverables evolve quickly, workloads fluctuate, and external priorities create additional burden on schedule. This leads me to an unresolved question that the article does not fully address: is being "all-in" a stable state, or is it something teams move in and out of as project demands intensify? If commitment fluctuates, then perhaps the real challenge is not achieving an all-in moment, but sustaining trust through the unavoidable cycles of imbalance.

What the article ultimately leaves me with is not a checklist, but a lens through which I will approach my team. My end takeaway is that being all-in is less about intensity and more about environment. When the air is right, when differences in personalities and opinions are welcomed rather than shut-off, commitment follows. And this is not because it is demanded, but because it makes sense to give your best effort to a process that recognizes it, that recognizes you.